

The Classical period

Influenced by the rational thinking of the Enlightenment, music in the Classical period (c.1750–1820) rejected polyphony and counterpoint in favor of shorter, simpler melodies with accompaniment.

SEE ALSO

◀ 130–131 Chord types

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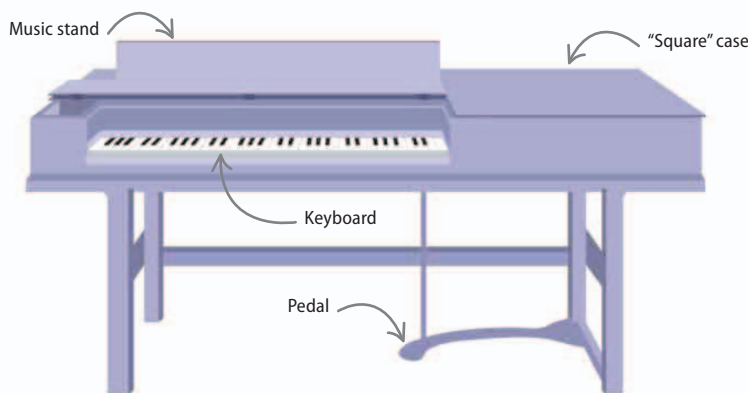
◀ 204–207 Classical music

Classical balance

After 1750, the impact of the Enlightenment principles of clarity, balance, and restraint were increasingly felt. A new simplicity infused the music, replacing Baroque complexity and showy ornamentation with musical ideas and structures that a listener could follow with ease.

▷ Architectural influence

The proportions of classical buildings like the Parthenon in Athens, Greece, inspired the new fashion for simplicity and balance.



Keyboard music

During the Classical period, the pianoforte (literally meaning soft-loud) gradually replaced the harpsichord as the most popular keyboard instrument. It was favored because pressing the pedal moved the dampers away from the strings so they continued to sound. This allowed pianists to play smooth melodies with expressive phrasing.

◁ Square piano

More compact than the “grand,” the square piano became a popular home instrument that was more suited in size and shape to the domestic room.

Alberti bass

The Alberti bass is a useful device found widely in Classical keyboard music. Consisting of repeated broken chords in the left hand, it provides a gentle, continuous, harmonic underpinning to a graceful tune that is being played by the right hand. Devised by composer Domenico Alberti (1710–1740), it was widely copied by later composers.



△ Mozart's Sonata in C, K. 545

Mozart's Sonata in C major uses an Alberti bass as a simple broken-chordal accompaniment to a charming melody.